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Economies of Studying Religion

Clayton Crockett

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The Journal of Cultural and Religious Theory is committed to advancing critical discourses aiming to (re)define the nature of disciplinary and inter-disciplinary scholarship in religion and culture studies. In a series of feature articles, the editors and members of the editorial board will address a wide range of issues in cultural and religious theory.

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Religion is about a certain about. What religion is about, however, remains obscure for it is never quite there—nor is it exactly not there. Religion is about what is always slipping away. It is, therefore, impossible to grasp what religion is about—unless, perhaps, what we grasp is the impossibility of grasping... This strange slipping away is no mere disappearance but a withdrawal that allows appearances to appear.

-- Mark C. Taylor, *About Religion*

_One of the significant problems for both understanding and living today involves the unrestrained proliferation of capital. In traditional Christianity, the prohibition against usury means that charging money for time is sinful because humans presume to buy and sell time, which is deemed God's possession. Of course, we could not conceive of modern society and economy without the practice of charging interest. One possibility for religious studies then, is to use economic concepts to understand religious phenomena, broadly following Marx. Here I am thinking of Mark Taylor's essay 'Discrediting God,' as well as some of Derrida's philosophical reflections in 'White Mythology' and *Specters of Marx*. The other side of this agenda would involve using religious and theological terms to critique and understand the workings of our economy. Here one could think of the market as God, and grapple with notions of investment, speculation and faith. It is intriguing to explore the multivalent resonance of words such as interest, speculation and credit in both philosophical-religious and economic contexts.

It is our epoch which has discovered theology. One no longer needs to believe in God. We seek rather the 'structure,' that is, the form which may be filled with beliefs, but the structure has no need to be filled in order to be called 'theological.' Theology is now the science of nonexistent entities, the manner in which these entities' divine or anti-divine, Christ or Antichrist' animate language and make for it this glorious body which is divided into disjunctions.¹

1. the experience of _belief_, on the one hand (believing or credit, the fiduciary or the tr
2. the experience of the unscathed, of _sacredness_ or _holiness_, on the other.[~2]

the gap between the opening of this possibility (as a universal structure) and the determinat

¹Gilles Deleuze, *The Logic of Sense*, translated by Mark Lester (New York: Columbia University Press, 1990), p.281.

Notes

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²Jacques Derrida, 'Faith and Knowledge: the Two Sources of 'Religion' at the Limits of Reason Alone,' in *Religion*, edited by Jacques Derrida and Gianni Vattimo (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1998, p.33.